

BENGAL FLORICAN

Houbaropsis bengalensis

Habitat: Grasslands of UP, the Nepal Terai, Assam and Arunachal Pradesh

Reason for decline: Land use change

HIGH

SHUTTERSTOCK

BUSTARDS GO BUST

TREND: Four species of bustards, a group of iconic grassland birds, are found in India. All four are specialised to open natural ecosystems (ONEs). Of these, the population of the Lesser florican, which breeds in fragments of grasslands, is less than 900 individuals. The Great Indian bustard has only 100–150 individuals, most of which survive in the Desert National Park of Rajasthan, where captive breeding has been started. The Bengal florican is restricted to the Himalayan Terai and the grasslands of northeastern India, with a South Asian population of under 400 individuals.

WHY: Bustard habitations have faced tremendous loss and change since the 1980s owing to infrastructural and developmental activities by humans.

A BIRD'S URBAN NIGHTMARE

Bright lights and loud noises in cities heighten bird sensitivity. The former can confuse birds and increase the risk of their crashing into the glass facades of buildings. The SoIB report says more than 60 species from 33 families of birds are affected by such collisions or electrocution by power lines in India. Loud noises can cause birds to sing louder, or at a different pitch or abandon their habitat in fright. V. Santharam, ornithologist and director of the Institute of Bird Studies and Natural History at the Rishi Valley School in Andhra Pradesh, points to another unfortunate trend—irresponsible bird-watching in urban sanctuaries. "People play bird sounds to draw them out," he says, "little realising it frightens them and forces them to either flee territory or expose themselves to predators."

India is also losing bird species to illegal hunting and trade. Only last year, more than 1,700 Alexandrines, Ring-necked and Blossom-headed parakeet fledglings were seized from the bird market in Jama Masjid in Old Delhi. "The deplorable ways in which these birds are poached, transported and handled causes their death before they can be rescued," says Satyanarayan. And whether they survive or not, the fact that traded birds are removed from their source populations impacts the wild population and their future.

BIRD SURVIVAL ALSO STANDS threatened for another simple reason: the absence of enough avian medicine specialists and hospitals. That job is right now being done by the Wildlife SOS facilities in Delhi NCR and Agra, which alone rescue and treat between 3,000 and 5,000 birds annually, among them owls, hornbills, flamingoes, egrets, eagles, kites, peafowls, ducks and parakeets. Theirs is a dedicated avian treatment centre for birds, including raptors, the classification given to birds of prey. For the Wildlife SOS team of veterinary doctors, it is as much a matter of getting the line of treatment right as of time. "Avian medicine is nascent in India," says Dr Abhishek Singh, senior veterinary officer, Wildlife SOS. "We are still perfecting medical procedures for wild birds, be it endoscopy, anaesthesia or blood draw, as birds are extremely fragile and delicate. Stress-free handling and observation are as important as the treatment." The NGO has plans to establish Delhi NCR's first avian hospital and is raising the Rs 2.5-3 crore needed to set up such a facility, which is expected to be a game-changer in helping increase the survival of birds. "India needs this facility," says Satyanarayan.

Especially as birds get injured or traumatised far more easily than mammals, as avian vet Dr Shiwani Tandel of Phoenix Veterinary Speciality in Mumbai points out. "Mammals have a diaphragm that separates the chest and the abdominal cavity," she explains. "Birds don't have this and their muscular wall itself is thin. So, even if the trauma is blunt, it can lead to internal bleeding. The smallest of cuts makes it difficult for birds to fly, and sharp trauma slices into their organs immediately. Additionally, birds have a high heart rate. If, in mammals, it is 120 or 140, it is double, almost 230-240, in birds. So, they also tend to bleed more readily, and get so scared that they go into shock." Birds also do not have a bladder, which means they have a higher chance of getting dehydrated than mammals—and faster.